



THE YOGA SENSEI • FREE GUIDE

Yoga for Beginners

The Starter Guide

Everything you need to begin — the gear that's worth it, eight foundational poses, a 10-minute routine, and what to skip. No flexibility required.

START HERE

You're more ready than you think

You don't need to be flexible, fit, or to buy anything to start yoga. You need a clear bit of floor and ten quiet minutes. This guide is the calm, no-hype version of starting: what actually matters, what you can safely ignore, and a routine you can do tomorrow morning.

I'm Marvin. I've practised for years — I'm not a certified instructor, and I write every word on The Yoga Sensei myself. Everything here is what I'd tell a friend who asked, "how do I start?"

How to use it. Skim it once, then keep the 10-minute routine somewhere you'll see it. Every underlined link opens a fuller free guide, a researched product, or the study behind a claim — all on tap if you want to go deeper.

This is general guidance, not medical advice. If you have an injury or health condition, or you're pregnant, check with your doctor before starting.

Almost nothing — but a good mat helps

The honest answer is that you can start with no equipment at all. The one thing worth buying is a mat: a grippy surface stops your hands and feet sliding apart, which is the single most common beginner frustration. Below are the mats I actually recommend, by budget.

Gaiam Premium 6mm — [View on Amazon](#)

Budget + cushioned. Soft underfoot and cheap — the easiest first mat for most beginners.

Retrospec Solana ½" — [View on Amazon](#)

Budget + extra-thick. Kind to sore knees and wrists on hard floors; the trade-off is a little less stability.

Jade Harmony — [View on Amazon](#)

Best grip + eco. Natural rubber, superb dry grip. Note: contains latex — skip if you're allergic.

Liforme Original — [View on Amazon](#)

Premium + alignment. A printed alignment guide on the surface that helps you place hands and feet.

Manduka PRO — [View on Amazon](#)

Buy-it-for-life. Heavy and near-indestructible with a lifetime guarantee; slippery until broken in.

Want the full breakdown? See [the best yoga mats for beginners](#) and [how to choose a yoga mat](#).

Nice to have later (not now): two [yoga blocks](#) and a [strap](#) bring the floor closer while your flexibility builds. What to skip at the start: fancy clothes, apps, and anything you saw on Instagram. Add a prop only when a pose actually asks for it.

Some product links below are affiliate links: if you buy through them I may earn a small commission, at no extra cost to you. I only list gear I would actually use, researched from specs and real reviews — no invented lab tests.

Eight poses to learn first

Learn these eight and you can follow almost any beginner class. Move slowly, breathe through your nose, and bend your knees whenever you need to — a long, straight back always beats straight legs.

Mountain Pose (Tadasana)

Stand tall, feet hip-width, weight even, crown lifting. The quiet base for every standing pose. Ease off if: you feel light-headed — soften the knees.

Cat-Cow (Marjaryasana–Bitilasana)

On hands and knees: inhale and arch, exhale and round. Warms the spine in under a minute. Ease off if: your wrists complain — come to fists or forearms.

Child's Pose (Balasana) • [full guide](#)

Hips back toward the heels, arms forward, forehead down. Your rest button — return to it any time. Ease off if: your knees hurt — widen them or add a cushion.

Downward Dog (Adho Mukha Svanasana) • [full guide](#)

Hips up and back into an inverted V. Bend the knees freely; the straight back is the goal. Ease off if: wrists ache — press the floor away, share the load.

Cobra (Bhujangasana) • [full guide](#)

Lie on your front and lift the chest with the back muscles, hands light. A gentle, opening backbend. Ease off if: your lower back pinches — lift lower.

Warrior II (Virabhadrasana II) • [full guide](#)

Step wide, turn one foot out, bend that knee over the ankle, reach the arms long. Strong and steady. Ease off if: the front knee caves in — track it over the toes.

Standing Forward Fold (Uttanasana)

Hinge from the hips and fold over soft knees, head heavy. Lets the whole back of the body release. Ease off if: you feel dizzy rising — come up slowly.

Sun Salutation A (Surya Namaskar A) • [full guide](#)

The flowing sequence that links several of these poses, one breath per move. The heart of most classes. Ease off if: you're rushing — slow the breath or do fewer rounds.

A gentle 10-minute morning flow

This is the one thing to keep. Move slowly, one breath at a time, and skip anything that doesn't feel right first thing.

1. Child's Pose — settle and breathe (1 min)
2. Cat-Cow — warm the spine (1 min)
3. Downward Dog — wake the back body (5 breaths)
4. Standing Forward Fold — let the head hang (a few breaths)
5. One or two Sun Salutations — build gentle heat (2–3 min)
6. Cobra — open the chest (a few breaths)
7. Warrior II — energise, each side (a few breaths)
8. Seated twist, then rest — finish calm (1–2 min)

Follow the full version, with cues and 5/15/30-minute options, in the [morning yoga routine guide](#). Ten minutes most days beats an hour once a week.

A gentle two-week rhythm

Week 1 — just show up. Three short sessions. Do only the first four poses for 5–10 minutes. The goal is the habit, not the depth.

Week 2 — add a little. Three or four sessions of 10–15 minutes. Add a Sun Salutation and Warrior II. Notice what's already easier.

After that — keep the routine. Stick with the 10-minute flow most mornings, and explore new poses when you're curious.

Five beginner mistakes

Rushing the breath. Let slow, nose breathing set the pace — not the other way around.

Chasing flexibility. You get flexible by practising; you don't need it to begin. Forcing a stretch is how people get hurt.

Holding the breath. It sneaks in the moment a pose gets hard. Keep it flowing and the pose gets easier.

Comparing yourself. To the person next to you, or to a video. Their body and years of practice are not yours.

Skipping the final rest. Two quiet minutes at the end is where the practice settles. Don't cut it.

When to take it easy

Yoga is generally safe when practised mindfully, but go gently, get a professional's eye, or skip poses if you have a recent injury, a back/neck/wrist/shoulder problem, uncontrolled high blood pressure, or you're pregnant. Sharp pain, dizziness, or pressure in the head are stop signals — come out of the pose. None of this is medical advice; when in doubt, ask your doctor.

Sources & further reading

The research behind the health notes in this guide — all free to read:

[NCCIH — Yoga: What You Need To Know](#)

Plain-language overview of yoga, benefits and safety, from the US National Institutes of Health.

[Pascoe et al. \(2017\) — Yoga and stress-related physiological measures \(meta-analysis\)](#)

Reviews of yoga link a regular practice to lower stress and cortisol; the studies are small and mixed.

[Bhavanani et al. — How effective is Sun Salutation... \(24-week study\)](#)

Students who practised Sun Salutations six days a week improved push-ups and sit-ups.

[CDC — Physical Activity Guidelines for Adults](#)

About 150 minutes of moderate movement a week; short daily sessions add up fast.

Keep going (free on the site)

- [Yoga for Beginners — the full guide](#)
- [Sun Salutation A — step by step](#)
- [Best yoga mats for beginners](#)

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— Marvin, The Yoga Sensei · hello@theyogasensei.com